PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep Grand Cherokee ZJ

1993–1998 · ZJ · ZG · 5.9 Limited

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust is the deal-breaker**
  OffroadXtreme says nearly every ZJ outside the desert has some rust, usually on the lower doors, the rockers and the bottom of the hatch, which can stop it opening. Heavy rust in the unibody frame rails is a reason to walk away.

- [ ] **Test for death wobble at 35–50 mph**
  Hit a bump in that speed range and feel for violent shaking from the front axle. OffroadXtreme says the lower track bar bolt is usually the cause, though worn tie-rod ends, ball joints and bushings also contribute. NHTSA recalled some 1993 trucks for front lower control arm cam bolts (93V-051).

- [ ] **Work the transfer case through every mode**
  Find out whether it has Command-Trac, Selec-Trac or Quadra-Trac, then shift through every position on a loose surface. OffroadXtreme says Selec-Trac linkages often stick, and many owners swap to the simpler part-time NP231. Quadra-Trac needs four matching tires; NHTSA recalled 1996 trucks because the front axle could overheat on the temporary spare.

- [ ] **Find the leaks**
  On the 4.0, OffroadXtreme lists the rear main seal, oil pan gasket, valve cover gasket and oil filter adapter gasket. On the V8s it's the rear main, the valve covers and the oil pressure sending unit. Most are easy fixes, but a rear main can be a multi-day job.

- [ ] **Watch the temperature gauge**
  OffroadXtreme lists an insufficient cooling system among the common ZJ faults. Let the truck idle hot, then drive it up a hill, with the A/C on if it has it. A tired radiator or fan clutch is cheaper to fix before you tow or wheel it.

- [ ] **Test the small stuff**
  OffroadXtreme's list: rear hatch stuck shut, failed alarm systems, broken auto-dimming mirrors and dead rear wiper motors. On a Limited, check the overhead trip computer and the EVIC warning display too.

- [ ] **Check the recalls were done**
  Two big ones: 13V-252, where Chrysler inspected the rear structure and fitted a tow hitch to protect the fuel tank in rear impacts, and 02V-053, a secondary detent for a shifter that could appear to be in Park when it wasn't. A Jeep dealer can check the VIN.

- [ ] **Know what you're buying**
  1993–95 trucks have the driver's airbag only and pre-OBD-II diagnostics; 1996–98 trucks have dual airbags and OBD-II. A real 5.9 Limited has a louvered hood, a mesh grille, 16 in five-spoke wheels and came only in Deep Slate, Stone White or Bright Platinum. OffroadXtreme warns that the factory axles can struggle behind the 5.9.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Fuel tank leak risk in rear impacts**
  1993–1998 · NHTSA 13V-252
- [ ] **Shifter can rest out of Park**
  1993–1998 · NHTSA 02V-053
- [ ] **Front axle overheating on the temporary spare**
  1996 · NHTSA 98V-006
- [ ] **Front lower control arm cam bolts**
  1993 · NHTSA 93V-051
- [ ] **Liftgate latch bumpers swell**
  1993 · NHTSA 93V-055
- [ ] **Steering column shaft pin**
  1993 · NHTSA 93V-210
- [ ] **Inadvertent airbag deployment**
  1997 · NHTSA 97V-080
- [ ] **Brake booster vacuum reservoir diaphragm**
  1998 · NHTSA 98V-023

- [ ] **5.9 Limited**
  1998 only. Look for working hood louvers, a mesh grille, unique five-spoke 16 in wheels, unique rocker moldings, a chrome exhaust tip and a 46RE with 3.73 gears and a rear Trac-Lok. US colors were Deep Slate, Stone White and Bright Platinum only.
- [ ] **1993–95 vs 1996–98**
  1996-on trucks have new bumpers and side cladding, a larger grille, a passenger airbag, an OBD-II port under the dash, a three-spoke wheel with cruise buttons, and raised metal 4×4 badges instead of decals.
- [ ] **Transfer case**
  Command-Trac (NP231, part-time, 1993–95), Selec-Trac (NP242, part-time or full-time) or Quadra-Trac (NV249, full-time). All three use a lever beside the gear selector; read the tag on the case to be sure.
- [ ] **Rear axle**
  Dana 35, Dana 44 or Chrysler 8.25 depending on year, engine and package. Read the tag on the cover or housing before buying gears, lockers or shafts.
- [ ] **Grand Wagoneer (1993)**
  A Limited with standard 5.2 V8 and Quadra-Trac, woodgrain vinyl on the fenders, doors and tailgate, chrome Grand Wagoneer badges, no lower cladding and a beige interior; 6,378 built.
- [ ] **Orvis and Up Country**
  Orvis Limiteds (1995–97) are Moss Green (or Light Driftwood in 1997) with roan red accents and green-and-tan leather. The Up Country package (1993–97) has taller springs, longer bump stops and heavier German gas shocks mounted upside down, for about 1 in more height.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/grand-cherokee-zj/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks